

Island woman's origins still hotly debated

Alaska theory, despite support, angers experts, traditionalists

By Barney Brumfaham

What would you think if the stoic Lone Woman of San Nicolas Island turned out to have been an Alaskan, not a local Indian?

Or more, at anyone having the nerve to challenge one of our most cherished legends?

Maria Daly, chronicler of the Channel Islands, felt the savage whip of academics a few years ago. That's because she ventured to write an article in "California History" that the Alaskan scenario should be explored.

After she presented a paper to archaeologists meeting at the Museum of Natural History a few years ago, she got letters slamming her ideas as absurd.

"People were upset. I got a bunch of letters that this was an absurd hypothesis," she said. "People don't want their bubbles to be burst."

"I'm not saying she is or isn't Alaskan," Daly said, just that the question needs to be examined. After my recent Santa Barbara Yesterdays column, "Los Olivos history buff Jim Norris also questioned the origin of 'Juana Maria,' which appeared with my column.

Rodman said Southern California historians had raised questions about it. The woman pictured appears well-fed despite her many years subsisting on island fare, and younger than someone described as middle-aged.

Norris is suspicious of it. "Do we have any other Santa Barbara photos from 1853?" he asked.

The woman died seven weeks after her rescue, apparently as a rejection to rich foods she was offered. In her paper, Daly, of the Santa Cruz Island Foundation, raises some key points. First of all, residents of San Nicolas, one of the four southernmost Channel Islands, were Gabriellino Indians. Those of the four northern ones were Chumash, she said.

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Santa Barbara YESTERDAYS



This plaque in the Santa Barbara Mission honors "Juana Maria," the Lone Woman rescued from San Nicolas Island in 1853. The exact location of her grave is unknown.

counts. Emma Hardacre, a Santa Barbara woman who studied the Lone Woman legend years after Juana Maria's death, doubted that she was an island Indian, according to Daly. She behaved like a woman "who had knowledge of the amenities of life," Hardacre said, not like someone raised on a barren island.

Then there were the dogs. When other hunters George Nidever and Charley Brown, a German whose real name was Carl Dittman, rescued Juana Maria, they found wild dogs on San Nicolas.

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white color," Nidever said. "I have seen the same kind of dogs among the Northwest Indians."

Nidever went back to shoot the dogs so he could run sheep there. His son later reported that Nidever told him they were "of the Alaskan breed."

Indians from the north, particularly peoples from Kodiak Island and the Aleutian Islands, participated in the California sea otter trade on and around San Nicolas during the first part of the 19th century," Daly said.

Juana Maria's story was fictionalized in the 1961 book by Scott O'Dell, "Island of the Blue Dolphins."

Botanist's bust gets a facelift

By Victor Irujo

You might say Francesco Franceschi is back where he belongs.

On Saturday morning, an 80-ton crane lifted the sculpture of Franceschi's head and placed it on a large slab of rock where it had once stood about 50 years ago at the outer edge of Franceschi Park.

Now Franceschi, the Italian botanist who is credited with bringing many exotic plant species to California, is back on his perch overlooking Santa Barbara.

"It's an very pleased," his granddaughter Ernestina Franceschi Femi of Santa Barbara said as she looked up at the stone sculpture. "It must be understood that when he lived, he loved plants and beautiful everywhere he went. This represents the beauty he left here."

"The younger generation should know what he left behind."

What had been left behind for some 50 years was the 5-ton sculpture. It had toppled over and been forgotten as it lay nestled among eucalyptus trees and boulders a few feet from where it now stands along Mission Ridge Road.

Santa Barbara poet Ashleigh Brilliant discovered the sculpture about a year ago and led the effort



A worker sandblasts graffiti off the bust of Francesco Franceschi after it was lifted on a slab of rock at Franceschi Park in Santa Barbara.

to restore it to its proper place. "It's a great piece of art," said a Santa Barbara landmark, "brilliant said. 'I can't tell you how happy I am and so is everybody else that's here.'"

"It's made a lot of people happy, especially the Italian people."

It was the Italian American Boot Club that came to the sculpture's rescue.

After reading about a month ago of the fallen sculpture and the effort to save it, club member and construction company owner Ugo Melchiorri began working out plans to lift the bust back into place.

The lifting operation, which started at 7 a.m. Saturday, required stone masons, sandblasters, a sculptor and a crane. The work was all done by volunteers.

Steel rods and cement were used to make certain the sculpture doesn't topple over again. The nose has chipped off but will be replaced.

"Considering what the man has done for the community, it's only right that he be back up in a place of honor," said Walter Orto, a member of the Italian American Boot Club.

Driver jailed after high-speed chase

News-Press staff report

"The California Highway Patrol arrested a Santa Barbara man Saturday after a high-speed chase that began on Highway 101 and ended on De la Vina Street in Santa Barbara.

CHP Officer Roger Runjavec attempted to pull over a driver headed south on 101 near the Las Positas Road exit at 12:58 p.m. for driving a car that appeared to

have been lowered. The driver of the low-rider did not stop and instead sped away, turning off on Mission Street and heading east. The driver then turned north on De la Vina and suddenly came to a stop.

Gabriel Flores of Santa Barbara faces charges of evading arrest, driving with a suspended license and operating a vehicle too low to the ground.

NORTH COUNTY DEATHS

COKE, Maryann: 62, of Santa Maria; died Thursday; no visitation; memorial service 10 a.m. Monday at Dudley-Hoffman Columbarium. Garden, cremation and private interment were requested; arrangements by Dudley-Hoffman Mortuary.

FOX, Doyle Edward: 77, of El Centro, formerly of Santa Maria; died Thursday; visitation 8 a.m. Wednesday at Dudley-Hoffman Mortuary in Santa Maria; grave

side service to follow at 1 p.m. Wednesday in Santa Maria Cemetery.

SEECH, Albert: 63, of Vandenberg Village; died Thursday; no visitation; memorial service 7:30 p.m. today at Donato Masonic Temple, 420 E. El Centro; interment will be private; donations may be made to Shriners Hospital for Crippled Children, 3160 Geneva St., Los Angeles, 90020; arrangements by Starbuck-Lind Mortuary.

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An Environmental Assessment (EA) was prepared for the Delta-Eutricia Island-Lone Woman Wildlife Services (ALWS) Program and a Finding of No Significant Impact (FONSI) was signed in December 1992. Subsequently, the National Audubon Society and Santa Barbara Audubon Society prepared a Supplemental Assessment (SEA) for the ALWS Program on Vandenberg Air Force Base (VAFB) which concludes that there will be no significant environmental impact.

In support of the NASA/Goddard Space Flight Center, McDonnell Douglas Aerospace's developers of the Delta II as VAFB. The ALWS Program which provides launch services for medium class satellite payloads, plans to launch its first Delta II in May 1994. The SLG-DW complex was recently modified to accept the Delta II rocket and is located on North VAFB approximately 3,000 feet from the coast. Existing wildlife processing and payload processing facilities on Vandenberg will be used. Two NASA launches per year are projected if contract options are exercised.

Concerned for the original project was developed by the State Historic Preservation Officer, California Coastal Commission, etc. The SEA was prepared to address launches during the California least and western snowy plover nesting season. Formal Consultation under Section 7 of the Endangered Species Act has been completed and a No Jeopardy Opinion was rendered by the U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service.

The EA, SEA and FONSI are available at the Lompoc, Santa Maria and Santa Barbara public libraries, as well as the UCSB library. Questions or comments may be submitted to 308 SPWET, Attn: Mr. G. Sanchez, 804 13th Street Suite 1, RM 7015, Vandenberg AFB, CA 93437-5242. Or contact 30 SPWPA at (805) 734-8232, extension 63595.

EAR RESPONSIBLE COMMENTS
DOCTOR, WHY DOES MY EAR CANAL HURT?
The human ear canal is a convoluted long passage leading from the outside environment to the eardrum. Normally the ear canal is dry. Small glands at the entrance of the ear canal produce cerumen or ear wax which acts as a barrier against infection. When the ear canal becomes wet from swimming, perspiration or irritation, one of several medical problems may occur.

OTITIS EXTERNA — This is an infection of the external ear canal. It may be due to injury from insect, infection, or excessive moisture.

Tinnitus — Otitis Externa may result from irritation from vigorously cleaning one's ear with a dry Q-tip, paper clip, or fingernail. If you must use a cotton swab, moisten it with body oil or baby oil before using it on your ear canal.

Swimmer's Ear — Starts an infection of the skin lining the ear canal. It occurs when the ear canal has been exposed to water or a foreign object of some while swimming, diving or showering. It can be prevented by putting the ear canal with a Q-tip dipped in rubbing alcohol to evaporate the residual water.

OTOMYCOSIS — A fungus or yeast infection of the external ear canal occasionally seen in patients who are diabetic, have had a prolonged course of antibiotics or corticosteroids, and those who use immunosuppressive patients receiving chemotherapy or suffering from AIDS-related disorders. The most common fungus is aspergillus niger. Ear drops containing acetic acid (white vinegar) may be helpful.

PREVENTION — It is important to keep your ears dry. After swimming or taking a shower the ears should be wiped thoroughly, but gently with a soft cloth. Anyone with a perforation (hole) in the eardrum should avoid getting water in the ear canal. This can be prevented by using commercial ear plugs or tampo in the ear canal when showering. Ear plugs may be used for swimming only, but a doctor is recommended for diving.

If these basic hygienic techniques do not control the problem, you should see an ear specialist.

THE EAR DOCTOR
J. DiBarbano, M.D.
Medical Director

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Ho, hum?

Or anger at anyone having the nerve to challenge one of our most cherished legends?

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That's because she ventured to suggest in an article in "California History" that the Alaskan scenario should be explored.

After she presented a paper to archeologists meeting at the Museum of Natural History a few years ago, she got letters slamming her ideas as absurd.

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"I'm not saying she is or isn't" Alaskan, Dally said, just that the question needs to be examined.

After my recent Santa Barbara Yesterdays column, Los Olivos history buff Jim Norris also questioned the origin of "Juana Maria."

That was what Santa Barbara Mission padres named the woman after she was rescued in 1853 after an 18-year solitary sojourn on the bleak island.

She was accidentally left behind when all other Indians were evacuated from San Nicolas in about 1835. "No one says 'Juana Maria' was Chumash except a Harrington interviewee many years after the event," Norris said. John P. Harrington was a noted local researcher into Chumash culture.

"I would suggest she was Alaskan Indian left with otter hunters around 1805-20," Norris said.

Norris and Michael Redmon, li-

brarian at the Santa Barbara Historical Society Museum, also questioned the authenticity of a commonly used photo of "Juana Maria," which appeared with my column.

Redmon said Southern California historians had raised questions about it. The woman pictured appears well-fed despite her many years subsisting on island fare, and younger than someone described as middle-aged.

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Juana Maria's story was fictionalized in the 1961 book by Scott O'Dell, "Island of the Blue Dolphins."